Societal Impact: Labour, Misinformation and Safety

1. Labour market disruption
Automation driven by AI is expected to displace some tasks while creating others. Routine cognitive work, such as customer support and data entry, is most exposed. Without reskilling programmes and social safety nets, benefits may concentrate among capital owners while costs fall on displaced workers, widening inequality.

2. Misinformation
Generative models can produce realistic text, images and audio at negligible cost. Deepfakes and automated disinformation campaigns threaten elections and public trust. Proposed responses include content provenance standards such as watermarking and cryptographic signing, platform policies, and media literacy education.

3. Safety and environmental cost
As AI systems become more capable and autonomous, ensuring they behave as intended (alignment) and are robust to misuse becomes critical. Red-teaming and staged release help identify risks early. Training large models also consumes significant energy and water, so developers should report and reduce environmental footprints.

4. Regulation
The EU AI Act classifies systems by risk level, banning unacceptable-risk uses such as social scoring and imposing strict requirements on high-risk systems. Other frameworks, including the NIST AI Risk Management Framework, offer voluntary guidance centred on governing, mapping, measuring and managing risk.